Vikramaditya, the Mughals, Sher Shah Suri and Governor-General Warren Hastings. There are remains here from each era including an eighteenth-century sundial. Do not miss the neglected British graves below the walls. Their headstones make for interesting reading. Just south-west of the fort are the quarries that, in the third century BC, supplied the stone used by the Mauyans to carve the lions of Sarnath, now the national symbol. We will return to them in Chapter 3.

POPULATING INDIA

When India collided with Asia, it rejoined the broader ecological milieu of the rest of the world. Many people assume that the similarities between present-day Indian and African mammals (elephants, rhinos, lions, etc) are due to the fact that India was once attached to Africa. As we have seen, this cannot be the case because India separated from Africa during the age of the dinosaur. [8] The entry of large mammals into India was due to its geographical re-attachment to Eurasia and the shifting climatic zones that allowed or forced these animals to migrate into India. Take for instance a genetic study of the frozen remains of a Siberian mammoth that died 33,000 years ago. The scientists of the Max Planck Institute in Leipzig found that the Asian elephant is more closely related to the mammoth than to the African elephant. It appears that the genetic lines of the Asian and the African elephant separated six million years ago whereas the Asian elephants and the mammoths diverged only 440,000 years ago. [9]

Moreover, many Indian animals came into the subcontinent from the east. The tiger is one such example. There is some disagreement about the exact origins of the big cat. Some scholars claim a Siberian origin while others prefer to locate it in South China. Two-million-year-old remains of the tiger's ancestors have been found in Siberia, China, Sumatra and Java. However, the animal is a relative newcomer to India. The genetic data as well as fossil finds suggest that the Bengal tiger came to inhabit India fairly recently, perhaps no more than 12,000 years ago.